

INSTRUCTOR GUIDE

INSTRUCTOR GUIDE | SUGGESTED RESPONSES

Back from the task force

A guide to the case on multiple team membership, status differences, and returning to a team.

Central idea

The same person can have different standing in different teams. Maya has ordinary standing in Atlas but becomes an influential member of Helix. Returning to Atlas places her back among colleagues who do not automatically treat her contribution in the same way.

The leader can manage this transition through the work itself. Maya should receive an opportunity to use what she learned in a way that helps another Atlas member solve a real problem. This makes her contribution visible without requiring her to claim greater importance.

Recommended answer

CHOOSE OPTION C

Ask Maya and Ruben to adapt one idea and test it together. This connects Maya's outside experience to a problem Atlas already needs to solve. Ruben remains involved because he understands the local process. Their joint test gives the team something concrete to evaluate.

Why the other choices are weaker

Option A. Recognition may help Maya, but this choice places the prestige of Helix at the centre of the conversation. The team receives little evidence that Maya's experience will improve its work.

Option B. Maya's knowledge is used, but she receives sole ownership. Ruben may become defensive, and the team is encouraged to compare Maya's standing with his.

Option D. The immediate disagreement is avoided, but useful experience is discarded and the difficult return remains unaddressed.

Suggested wording for Sam

A WORKABLE OPENING

“Maya, you saw a different handover method during Helix. Ruben, you know where our current process works and where it breaks down. I would like the two of you to choose one small change that could help us catch late order updates. Adapt it to this shift, test it for one week, and bring the results back together. Tell us what worked, what did not work, and whether we should continue.”

This wording gives each person a clear contribution. Maya supplies the outside idea. Ruben supplies local knowledge. The team judges the result instead of deciding whose status claim is stronger.

Suggested responses

1. How does Maya’s standing differ between Atlas and Helix?

Maya has ordinary standing in Atlas. Her colleagues respect her, but senior members normally shape decisions. In Helix, her practical knowledge became central, senior people asked for her judgment, and her work entered the final proposal. Her relative standing was therefore higher in Helix than in Atlas.

2. Why might Helix’s visibility matter?

Helix was followed by senior management and worked on a company-wide problem. That visibility makes Maya’s position in Helix harder for her and her colleagues to dismiss as an unimportant temporary assignment. The research found that differences in relative standing were more strongly associated with teammate-focused behaviour when the outside team had higher public standing.

3. What could explain Ruben’s reaction?

Ruben may feel that Maya is questioning a process he designed. He may also believe that Helix lacked the practical constraints faced by Atlas. His reaction could reflect defensiveness, genuine technical disagreement, concern about disruption, or some combination. The case does not allow students to diagnose his motive.

4. Why is Option C preferable?

It turns the status issue into a shared task. Maya can show the value of her outside experience by helping Ruben and Atlas. Ruben can make the idea workable in the local setting. A small test also limits the cost if the Helix method does not fit.

5. What should Sam say?

A good answer explains why Maya and Ruben are both needed, names the problem they will address, keeps the test small, and gives them shared responsibility for reporting the result. Sam should avoid telling the team that Maya now knows best because she worked with senior managers.

6. What should the test contain?

Maya explains the part of the Helix method intended to capture late changes. Ruben identifies where it conflicts with Atlas’s timing, staffing, or layout. Together they create a simple adapted handover board. One shift uses it for a week. They record how many late changes were received, how many were missed, and whether the board created extra work or confusion. Maya and Ruben present the result together.

7. What evidence would be needed before claiming causality?

The case shows Maya returning with different standing and then behaving differently, but several other explanations remain possible. Her behaviour could reflect new knowledge, greater confidence, the selection process that placed her in Helix, or the specific problem Atlas faces. Stronger causal evidence would require repeated observations, direct measures of how Maya interprets her standing, a comparison group, or a design in which team assignments change for reasons unrelated to prior behaviour.

Teaching plan

A 25- to 35-minute discussion works well.

1. Allow five minutes for individual reading and a private vote.
2. Ask pairs to map Maya's two team positions and evaluate the four choices.
3. Take a second vote and ask students to defend their choice.
4. Develop Sam's exact wording and the one-week test as a group.
5. End by separating the practical recommendation from the limits of the evidence.

Useful extensions

Ask whether the advice would change if Helix were a little-known temporary group. The paper suggests that the comparison carries less weight when the outside team has lower public standing, although it does not show that the issue disappears.

Then reverse the situation: Maya holds high standing in Atlas but had low standing in Helix. The study found no reliable difference between the two directions of the status gap. Students can discuss why the same joint-work response may still be useful.

Evidence note for instructors

The paper analyses 692 returns by 364 outfield players in the 2017/18 men's Big Five European football leagues. Greater differences between focal-team and referent-team status were associated with more chances created for teammates after returning. The relationship became stronger as the external status of the referent team increased. The pattern did not appear for returners' own shots or total recorded activity. When chance creation was summed across returners in the same match, it was positively associated with team performance.

EVIDENCE BOUNDARY

The study is observational. It does not establish that status differences cause teammate-enabling behaviour, that teammate-enabling behaviour causes performance, or that the intervention proposed in this case will work in every workplace. The intervention is a grounded teaching application that managers can test on a small scale.

RESEARCH BASIS

Use the public research package for a fuller methods description and the reported analyses.

Van de Brake, "Returning with a Different Status Position: Status Inconsistency in Multiple Team Membership." Manuscript under review at Organization Science.

https://osf.io/esg7p/?view_only=7e898bf9fec24336b081e5c1e4b5ac10

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